

National Lok Dal (INLD) and have made a huge difference, with the community accounting for over 20 per cent of the vote. But Hooda, a Jat leader who was favoured over Bhajan Lal five years ago by the party high command mainly to attract Jat votes, seems to have badly dented the Chautalas. The INLD was always expected to be the main opposition. In alliance with the BJP, it has always performed better than it has otherwise. Yet, the alliance broke, with both parties blaming each other. Neither party budged from its calculations

be immodest and said the party was only looking to improve upon its performance. In 1991, when the party fought the polls alone, it managed only two seats. But it has done well piggy-backing on other parties, like forming a government with Bansi Lal's Haryana Vikas Party in 1996 and the INLD in 2000. Knowing its strengths and weaknesses, the BJP tried to unsuccessfully forge an alliance with Bhajan Lal's Haryana Janhit Congress.

A beleaguered Bhajan Lal and his son Kuldeep Bishnoi, still smarting under the "humiliation"

showed a marked rise in the Lok Sabha polls, getting 15.7 per cent of the vote. It can spoil anyone's party depending on how well it plays up the caste factor. The state is estimated to have a 17 per cent Scheduled Caste population while 19 per cent belong to the BC and OBC categories.

In fact, leaders and workers from different parties have been moving over to the Congress since the Lok Sabha polls. They seemed to have gauged which way the tide is turning. Even veterans like Sampat Singh who

THE BJP (LEFT) NURSES HOPES OF IMPROVING; BHAJAN LAL (RIGHT) IS FALTERING AFTER A GOOD START



HEMANT CHAWLA/www.indiatodayimages.com

THE BJP, WHICH HAS FORGED WINNING ALLIANCES IN THE PAST, IS going it alone this time while the tie-up between Bhajan Lal's eroded Haryana Janhit Congress and Mayawati's BSP has come undone.

and expectations, which in turn harmed their own interests, instead of the Congress's.

In the absence of any apparent anti-incumbency wave, the Chautalas are desperate. Having been a disaster in the previous two Lok Sabha and the 2005 Assembly polls, the party has forgotten the taste of triumph. It is now mainly harping on issues like "corruption and the deteriorating law and order situation" in the Congress regime. The BJP on its own has never been a big force in Haryana. Arun Jaitley, while releasing the manifesto, refused to

meted out at the hands of the Congress high command that denied the old warhorse the chief minister's crown in 2005, were a major threat to the party till now. It had fared well in the three by-elections last year and in the recent Lok Sabha polls. Its alliance with the BSP made it a formidable combination. But the merger is off now and several partymen have crossed over to the 'original' Congress leaving the 18-month-old party weaker.

The BSP is an unpredictable card. A party that polled under 5 per cent of the vote in 2005

served the Chautalas for over three decades crossed over to the Congress, sensing that a ticket would automatically translate into triumph.

But the Congress itself is ridden with factionalism with the likes of Birender Singh, Kiran Chaudhary, Kumari Selja and Rao Inderjit Singh challenging Hooda's dominance. While he had his say in the allocation of tickets, it obviously left many candidates sobbing and choosing to rebel. More than the external factors it is this one that looms large on Congress's chances in the polls. ■